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Thanks for Standing By Me

‘When we disembark, there’ll be police waiting for you at the gate.’

Alex Ferguson has all sorts of great qualities as a manager. Just remembering France 98, one stands out in particular: the boss sticks by his players and backs them, even through the very worst of times.

‘Just get yourself back to Manchester,’ he said to me. ‘Don’t worry about what anyone says. Get yourself back here, where people love you and support you. You can have your say back to the rest of them after the season begins.’

Some people have an idea that it’s something to criticize, but I can tell you that the boss’s loyalty to his players means they have cast iron respect for him as a man and absolute faith in him as a manager. One of the reasons I went to United in the first place was his attitude to young hopefuls: the boss made you feel like you were joining a family, not just a soccer club. And through thick and thin, beyond any disagreement or confrontation between us, it always felt like that at Old Trafford. The manager is the reason why. Knowing he was behind me really helped me get through that summer in 1998, and the early part of the season that followed.

While I was in America with Victoria, I had the chance to look at some of the English press coverage in the wake of what had happened in Saint-Etienne. Maybe I’d have been better off listening to the people who told me I shouldn’t. Even thousands of miles away, some of the headlines like ‘TEN HEROIC LIONS, ONE STUPID BOY’ hit me hard. I realized what I’d done but, at the same time, it seemed to me that the media reaction was way over the top: it was a soccer match that had brought all this on, after all. A big soccer match, yes. But did that justify the way the papers seemed to be treating me? I’d expected a backlash but I was shocked by the intensity of it. I